

POST INDEPENDENCE DEVELOPMENTS

RAJIV GANDHI'S ERA MODULE-12



RAJIV GANDHI

31 October 1984 - 2 December 1989



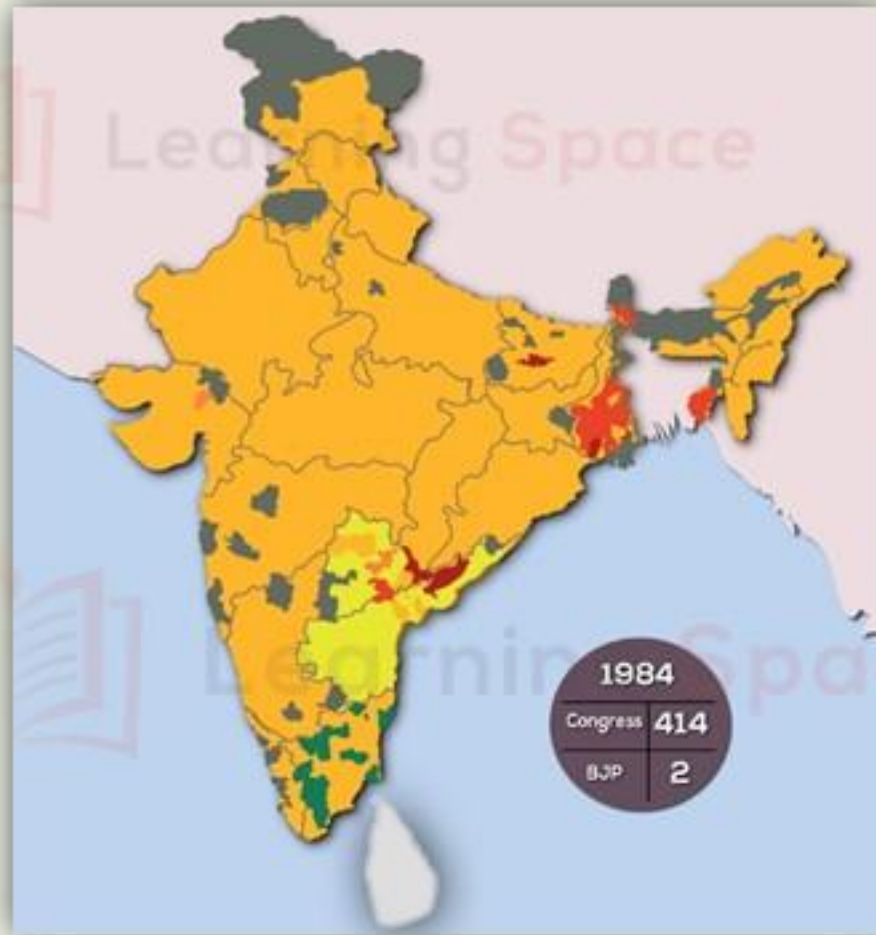
Operation Bluestar which ultimately led to the assassination of Indira Gandhi halted Hindu-Muslim tensions. Against these tensions, Rajiv Gandhi was sworn in as the Prime Minister.

BHOPAL GAS TRAGEDY



- 1** In December 1984, there was release of a deadly gas methyl isocyanate (MIC) from an American firm Union Carbide. The effects were devastating.
- 2** It turned out to be the worst industrial accident in human history killing over two thousand people and affecting about 50,000 people with illness and injury. The CEO of Union carbide was briefly arrested but soon released on bail and went back to New York.
- 3** Indian scientists visited Bhopal under Operation Faith to neutralize the remaining stocks of gas.
- 4** Questions were being raised on placing the hazardous industry in the city. There had been a history of minor accidents in the industry earlier as well and the factory was advised to be located in a safer and less populated area.

1984 ELECTIONS



- India witnessed General elections in December 1984.
- This election took place in the background of killing of Indira Gandhi.
- Rajiv Gandhi was presented as the logical heir of the Congress party.

RAJIV GANDHI'S PRIME MINISTERSHIP



- In the first year of his term the prime minister was often on tour, making his acquaintance with parts of the country.
- Everywhere, he met ordinary Indians and received their petitions, passing them on to the district administration for action.

PUNJAB



- 1 The Congress performed well in the polls capturing fifty percent of popular vote and almost 80 percent of seats in the Parliament.
- 2 The fear of secession was also looming large before the elections from the state of Punjab.
- 3 The leader of Akali Dal Sant Harchran Singh Longowal met Rajiv Gandhi in 1985 and both leaders signed an accord- agreeing to transfer Chandigarh to Punjab within a specified time frame, assuring Punjab a fair share of river waters and committing the government to a fresh review of centre-state relations in general.

PUNJAB



4

- President's Rule was to be revoked and state elections held.
- But this bonhomie was short lived when Longowal was shot by two men who felt that he betrayed the Sikh cause by making peace with the government.

5

- The Sant's death created a wave of popular support for his party.
- The Akali Dal won a comfortable majority, in the State Assembly for the first time in the province's history.

MILITANCY IN PUNJAB



- 1 But the acts of terror continued.
- 2 In a major operation in May 1988 commandos flushed out some fifty terrorists holed up in the Golden Temple complex.
- 3 Unlike Operation Bluestar, this assault was launched in daylight, so that the adversaries could be pinpointed more clearly.
- 4 In any case, these militants were not as well prepared or as motivated as Bhindranwale's men.
- 5 They retreated into the Temple's sanctum sanctorum; denied access to food and water, they surrendered seventy-two hours later.

NORTHEAST OF INDIA



- 1 The north-east is a region of violence and conflict, and hence also of migration.
- 2 Some of it is across national borders, as in the continuing immigration from Bangladesh. Others move within the region, some in search of jobs, some fleeing ethnic persecution.
- 3 There is also a growing number of 'environmental refugees'. There is a massive military presence in the north-east.

NORTHEAST OF INDIA



- 4 The states of the region variously border China, with whom India has fought a costly war, Bangladesh, with whom India has a profoundly ambivalent relationship, and Burma.
- 5 But it is not merely for external security that the Indian army has so many men here.
- 6 They are also needed to maintain the flow of essential goods and services, protect road and rail links, and, not least, suppress rebellion and insurgency.

ASSAM



- 1 The Nellie massacre was an incident of large scale riots in a village in Assam called Nellie.
- 2 The village is located in the central part of Assam, in the Bramhaputra Valley.
- 3 It took place on 18 February 1983. In the day long massacre, thousands of people were killed.

HISTORY OF NELLIE MASSACRE

- 1 In 1947 with the introduction of colonial borders, "free movement" within the subcontinent came to an end.
- 2 Sylhet was asked to vote in a referendum in 1947 about whether they would want to continue being a part of Assam and therefore India, or part of East Pakistan.
- 3 Ultimately, Assam was delighted when Sylhet joined East Pakistan
- 4 Migration between Sylhet and Assam was still taking place, whilst large numbers of the Bengali elite from Calcutta were also moving to Assam, causing apprehension from the native Assamese community, as the elite Bengalis from Calcutta were much more economically advantaged than them, often hiring the natives for labour work.
- 5 In 1951 Assam prepared The National Register of Citizens, where it contained the names of "Indian" citizens of Assam.



N E P A L

SIKKIM

BHUTAN

ASSAM

BIHAR

SYLHET

BANGLADESH

JHARKHAND

KOLKATA

ODISHA

TRIGGER BY INDIRA GANDHI



All Assam
Students' Union



All Assam Gana
Sangram Parishad

1

After Indira Gandhi's decision to give 4 million immigrants from Bangladesh the right to vote, there was a heightened prominence of the issue of foreign national in Assamese society against the inclusion of foreigners in the electoral rolls.

2

The AASU and AAGSP organisers called for a boycott of the election and violent incidents occurred during this period.

BY-ELECTIONS IN ASSAM



- 1** In 1978, Lok Sabha member died, necessitating a by-election. During the process of the election it was noticed that the electorate had grown phenomenally.
- 2** Investigation revealed that there had been mass inclusion of alleged illegal migrants. The All Assam Students Union (AASU) demanded that the elections be postponed until the names of "foreign nationals" were deleted from the electoral rolls. The AASU subsequently launched an agitation to compel the government to identify and expel illegal immigrants.
- 3** The ethnic clash that took place in Nellie was seen as a fallout of the decision to hold the controversial Assembly elections in 1983 (boycotted by the AASU) despite stiff opposition from several elements in the state. Central paramilitary force and 11 brigades of the Indian Army were deployed to guard Assam while the polls were scheduled to take place in phases

NATURE OF NELLIE MASSACRE



- 1 While most incidents of riots in post-Independent India have been urban in nature, the Nellie incident was rural.
- 2 The perpetrators of the riots were primarily the peasants of the indigenous groups of Tiwas and Koches inhabiting the area.
- 3 The victims of the riots were the Muslim peasants who had historically migrated from East Bengal during the colonial period.

TIWARI COMMISSION



ASSAM UNITED DEMOCRATIC FRONT

- 1** The official Tiwari Commission report on the Nellie massacre is still a closely guarded secret (only three copies exist).
- 2** The 600-page report was submitted to the Assam Government in 1984 and the Congress Government decided not to make it public, and subsequent Governments followed suit.
- 3** Assam United Democratic Front and others are making legal efforts to make Tiwari Commission report public, so that reasonable justice is delivered to victims, at least after 25 years after the incident.

FINDINGS OF THE REPORT



1 Police filed 688 criminal cases, of which 378 cases were closed due to "lack of evidence" and 310 cases were slated to be charged.

2 However, all these cases were dropped by the Government of India as a part of the 1985 Assam Accord and, as a result, not a single person received punishment.

ASSAM IN 1970s

- 1** In 1971 a huge number of refugees from East Pakistan went to Assam, causing already underlying tensions ultimately created by West Bengalis to shift heavily on the refugees from East Bengal coming in.
- 2** In 1979, the All Assam Student Union and All Assam Gan Sangram Parishad started a movement against what they labelled as "illegal migrants".
- 3** The powerful movement went on for six years resulting in a political party established to deal with illegal immigrants and more importantly resulted in an Assam Accord signed between both AASU and AAGSP and the government of India under Rajiv Gandhi in 1985.
- 4** The Accord said that all the relatives of people listed in the 1951 NRC along with the foreign migrants registered between 1961 and the midnight of 24th March 1971 will be accepted as legal residents of Assam and therefore India. The specific cut of date ultimately rendered all those refugees who fled violence and genocide in East Pakistan stateless.

ASSAM



- Here too President's Rule was ended and elections called. A student's union transformed itself into a political party, with AASU members creating the Asom Gana Parishad (AGP).
- When polls to the state assembly were held in December 1985 the AGP trounced the once-dominant Congress.

Thus, democracy was vindicated and elections were successful in the state of Assam.

MIZO CONFLICT



1

- In 1959, a famine took place in the Mizo hills.
- The population of rats had suddenly increased and it started attacking warehouses of grains causing a scarcity of food for humans.

2

- In March 1966, revolt broke out in the Mizo hills.
- It was a region bordering East Pakistan and were demanding a homeland of their own.
- A Mizo National Famine Front was formed, later replaced by the Mizo National Front to demand a separate state within the Union and eventually a separate country for itself.

MIZO CONFLICT



3 The leader of MNF met the military government of East Pakistan.

4 The military government offered Laldenga, the leader of MNF guns, money and a base to launch attacks from.

5 Young Mizos were recruited and trained in the use of modern weaponry.

6 MNF announced that the territory had seceded from the Indian Union and was now an 'independent' republic. They captured one main town Lungleh and capital Aizwal.

RESPONSE OF GOVERNMENT



1 Indians called in the army and air force. For the first time, Indian state used air force against its own citizens.

2 The rebels took refuge in the jungle. The ordinary Mizos were caught in the cross-fire between insurgents and the state.

3 In June 1986 the government of India signed a peace agreement with Laldenga. By its terms, the MNF rebels laid down their arms and were granted an amnesty against prosecution.

4 The government agreed to grant full statehood to Mizoram, and Laldenga himself assumed office as chief minister, taking over from the Congress incumbent.

TRIPURA



- 1 In Tripura, tribal activists had launched a struggle against the Bengalis who had migrated in large numbers to the state after Partition.
- 2 By some definitions the Tripura National Volunteers (TNV) qualified as 'terrorists', murdering and kidnapping civilians and ambushing police parties in pursuit of their ends.
- 3 In 1986 TNV guerrillas killed more than a hundred people.
- 4 However, in August 1988, the TNV leader Bijoy Hrangkhawl came out of hiding to sign an accord with the government.
- 5 His volunteers laid down their arms in exchange for more seats for tribals in the local legislature and the provision of rice and cooking oil at subsidized rates in tribal villages.

NEPALIS IN BENGAL



- 1 There were conflicts between different groups in the same state.
- 2 In Bengal, for instance, the Nepali-speaking population of the Darjeeling hills had begun asking for a state of their own.
- 3 Their leader was a former soldier named Subhash Ghisingh. Among his cadre Ghisingh commanded total and unquestioning support; at a word from him they could shut down all the schools and shops in the district.

NEPALIS IN BENGAL



4 His Gorkha National Liberation Front worked within the democratic process and outside it, sometimes petitioning Union ministers, at other times engaging in pitched battles with the police.

5 Through the latter half of 1986 the clashes were particularly intense.

6 Eventually, the prime minister met Ghisingh, persuading him to accept an autonomous hill council rather than a state for Nepali speakers.

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